Buy your crab precooked, or, for optimum freshness, buy it live and cook it yourself. Boiling is the most common way to cook a live crab, although it can also be steamed.

crab bisque

SERVES 4 **PREP** 45 MINS **COOK** 1 HR 10 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 2 MONTHS
BEFORE CREAM IS ADDED

1–2 cooked crabs, about 2¼lb (1kg) total weight
3½ tbsp butter
olive oil
1 onion, finely chopped
1 carrot, finely chopped
2 celery ribs, finely chopped
1 leek, finely chopped
½ fennel bulb, finely chopped
1 bay leaf
1 sprig of tarragon
2 garlic cloves, crushed
1in (2.5cm) piece fresh ginger, peeled and finely chopped
2½oz (75g) tomato purée
4 tomatoes, coarsely chopped
½ cup Cognac or brandy
½ cup dry white wine or vermouth
1¾ quarts (1¾ liters) fish stock
½ cup heavy cream
salt and freshly ground black pepper
pinch of cayenne pepper
juice of ½ lemon

1 Remove the crab meat from the shell and chop into small pieces. Chop the shell up coarsely and set both shell and meat to one side. Heat the butter and oil in a large saucepan over medium heat. Add the vegetables, herbs, garlic, and ginger. Cook, stirring occasionally, for 10 minutes or until softened.

2 Add the chopped shell, then stir in the tomato purée, tomatoes, Cognac, wine, and stock. Bring to a boil and simmer for 1 hour. Let cool slightly, then blend until smooth. Strain through a coarse sieve, pushing as much liquid through as you can with the back of a spatula, and then press through a fine sieve, making sure to remove the chopped shell.

3 Return the soup to the pan and bring to a boil. Add the crab meat and cream, then season to taste with salt and pepper and add cayenne and lemon juice to taste. Garnish with chives and serve in warm bowls.